

Demand for Slaves, Markets, and Social Betrayal: How the Slave Trade Shaped Mistrust in Africa*

Steve Berggreen[†] and Gunes Gokmen[‡]

August 28, 2026

Abstract

We examine the mechanisms through which the transatlantic slave trade eroded trust in Africa by creating incentives for kidnapping and social betrayal. Exploiting variation in slave prices and transaction costs, we show that the negative relationship between slave trade exposure and contemporary trust is concentrated where opportunistic enslavement was more profitable, owing to higher slave prices and lower transaction costs. Using child slave exports as a proxy for kidnapping-intensive procurement, we find that this form of enslavement accounts for much of the slave trade–mistrust relationship. Oral histories illustrate how mistrust was transmitted across generations, highlighting the cultural channel of persistence.

Keywords: Slave trade, mistrust, malaria, markets, kidnapping, trans-Saharan trade, African development.

JEL code: J15, N57, Z13.

*We thank Sascha Becker, Jutta Bolt, Mathieu Couttenier, Therese Nilsson, and seminar participants for their helpful comments.

[†]Global Policy Laboratory, Stanford Doerr School of Sustainability, Stanford University. Address: Environmental Social Sciences, Stanford University, Yang & Yamazaki (Y2E2) Building, 473 Via Ortega, Room 383, Stanford, CA 94305-4216. Email: stevebc@stanford.edu.

[‡]Lund University, Department of Economics. Address: Department of Economics, Lund University, P.O. Box 7080, 220 07 Lund, Sweden. Email: gunes.gokmen@nek.lu.se.

1 Introduction

Why do historical shocks continue to shape socio-economic behavior long after the conditions that produced them have disappeared? Research on the deep historical determinants of development shows that early institutional and economic experiences remain predictive of modern outcomes (Borcan, Olsson, and Putterman, 2018; Comin, Easterly, and Gong, 2010; Nunn, 2008; Putterman and Weil, 2010). Yet, evidence of persistence does not by itself reveal how historical experience becomes embedded and transmitted across time. We study this process through trust.

Although trust is a fundamental ingredient of economic development, cooperation, and collective action,¹ it varies dramatically across societies, with historical experiences of violence, predation, and social betrayal often leaving long-lasting imprints. Thus, a central challenge is to identify how such experiences become ingrained in social norms and get passed down through generations. The African slave trades provide a particularly useful setting in which to study these dynamics.

Research suggests that the transatlantic slave trade contributed to persistent mistrust across African communities (Nunn and Wantchekon, 2011). While this reduced-form relationship is well established, there is a lack of evidence on which features of the trade generated mistrust.² Through what micro-level processes did the slave trade generate a culture of mistrust? To address this gap in the literature, we examine whether the slave trade eroded trust through a specific form of social predation –kidnapping and betrayal within local communities.³

¹ E.g., Algan and Cahuc (2010); Greif (1993); Guiso, Sapienza, and Zingales (2006); Kim, Putterman, and Zhang (2022); Knack and Keefer (1997); Levi and Stoker (2000); Ostrom (1990); Putnam, Nanetti, and Leonardi (1993); Rothstein (2005); Sangnier and Zylberberg (2017); Tabellini (2010).

² Arguably, external and internal forms of predation may trigger distinct mechanisms. External threats can promote cooperation and facilitate state-building (Herbst, 2000; Tilly et al., 1992), while internal predation may erode trust and weaken collective institutions (Ostrom, 1990; Putnam, Nanetti, and Leonardi, 1993).

³ We use “kidnapping” and “social betrayal” interchangeably to refer broadly to methods of enslavement involving trickery, deceit, abduction or other forms of small scale violence, often perpetrated by a relative, neighbor, or local stranger.

We argue that the slave trade eroded trust not only through the scale of extraction, but through the manner in which captives were procured. Specifically, the economic incentives created by the slave trade fostered a culture of mistrust by making it profitable for individuals to betray or kidnap members of their own and neighboring communities and sell them into slavery. As external demand raised the returns to slave trade, kidnapping, deception, and the sale of neighbors or kin became increasingly common. In such an environment of ubiquitous insecurity, where people turned on one another, individuals had to maintain constant vigilance against being tricked, kidnapped, or sold into slavery, resulting in social betrayal and a profound erosion of trust. Mistrust was therefore an adaptive response to a setting in which ordinary social relationships could be used for predation. Although [Nunn and Wantchekon \(2011\)](#) discuss this possibility,⁴ the kidnapping mechanism has not been yet tested.

We start by presenting a simple framework where the profitability of capturing and selling others depends on slave prices and transaction costs. As external demand drove up prices, individuals were increasingly incentivized to prey upon their own community members (even kin) and kidnap them into slavery. As a result, an individual’s adaptive response would be to become less trusting in an environment of predation. Persistence arises when parents transmit these protective beliefs and behavioral rules to children, even as the historical environment changes. The result can be a culturally transmitted heuristic whose decay is substantially slower than the disappearance of the original incentives ([Giavazzi, Petkov, and Schiantarelli, 2019](#)).⁵

Historical and oral evidence support this transmission channel. Oral histories from West

⁴ For example, [Nunn and Wantchekon \(2011\)](#) write that “Unlike most other environments of conflict and insecurity, the slave trade had one unique feature: individuals could partially protect themselves by turning against others within their community. By engaging in trickery, local kidnappings, or other forms of small scale violence, one could exchange slaves for guns and iron weapons.” They further argue that a culture of mistrust may have evolved in this environment, which may persist to this day.

⁵ This mechanism can be summarized as follows. Higher returns to capture → more interpersonal predation → mistrust becomes individually adaptive → parents and communities transmit cautionary norms → mistrust persists after the original danger disappears.

Africa describe how fear of kidnapping shaped child-rearing and everyday social behavior: elders recall parents hiding children, restricting their movements, and warning them against strangers and travel outside the community, and describe these lessons being retold within families across generations, surviving colonization. While such accounts cannot on their own identify the causal effect of the slave trade, they illustrate a concrete channel through which historically adaptive mistrust could persist into the present. Our conceptual framework, combined with qualitative evidence, provides us with the following testable predictions.

First, the negative impact of the slave trade on trust should be stronger where slave prices were higher, as this would have incentivized higher rates of opportunistic enslavement. Using variation in malaria ecology as an exogenous source of slave price variation following [Esposito \(2022\)](#),⁶ we find stronger trust erosion among ethnic groups from malaria-prone regions – whose members commanded higher prices in the Atlantic slave trade.⁷

Second, the effects on mistrust should be greater for ethnic groups with lower transaction costs, as this would reduce the cost of opportunistic selling to nearby slave traders. Using data on historical travel times to international slave markets ([Whatley, 2022](#)), we document substantial heterogeneity in the effect of the slave trade on trust by transaction costs. The negative effects on trust hold for ethnic groups within about two weeks of travel time to the nearest slave port, and within about 50 days of travel to the nearest Saharan trade hub.⁸

Third, due to greater profitability, higher prices and lower transaction costs should increase kidnapping and social betrayal directly. Direct information on methods of enslavement is scarce. We therefore introduce the prevalence of child slaves as a proxy for kidnapping-intensive procurement, drawing on historical evidence that children were especially vulnerable to abduction and other opportunistic forms of enslavement.⁹ Using voyage records

⁶ [Esposito \(2022\)](#) shows that the demand for malaria resistant slaves surged following the spread of malaria across the American continent, leading to significantly higher prices for slaves from malaria suitable areas.

⁷ Following [Nunn and Wantchekon \(2011\)](#), we use five trust questions from the individual level Afrobarometer Survey Round 3 of 2005.

⁸ Saharan trade routes were more established and likely involved lower marginal trade costs, e.g. through established caravan networks, facilitating travel to longer distances.

⁹ See, e.g. [Lovejoy \(2006\)](#), [Sparks \(2014\)](#), and [Eltis and Engerman \(1993\)](#).

covering more than one million enslaved individuals,¹⁰ we show that both higher prices and lower transaction costs raised the likelihood of child slavery. For identification, we follow [Esposito \(2022\)](#), who uses a difference-in-differences strategy exploiting the rise in demand for malaria-resistant slaves after malaria became endemic in the Americas around 1690.

Fourth, putting it all together, locations with greater exposure to kidnapping (child slave exports) should experience the largest declines in trust –especially where this exposure occurred late in the slave trade with less time for intergenerational decay of the mistrust heuristic. Using georeferenced port data, we impute the extent of child slave exports at the ethnic group level through a calibrated spatial interpolation model. A simple mediation analysis reveals that most of the negative effect of slavery on trust is driven by child slavery.¹¹ We also find that, when we include measures of child and adult slave exports in the same regression, contemporary mistrust is more strongly associated with child exports, particularly with child exports during the nineteenth century. This pattern is consistent with kidnapping-intensive procurement playing a distinct role in the formation and persistence of mistrust.

To sum, the evidence we provide is consistent with the narrative that historical incentives, such as higher prices or lower costs, may have shaped opportunistic predatory behavior. This social betrayal, in turn, leads to rational mistrust by contemporaries. Such mistrust perpetuates via parental/social transmission, resulting in persistence of mistrust after the original incentives disappear.

Contribution to the literature– The literature documents that the levels of trust can be influenced by long-run factors –e.g., slave trade, medieval experience of self-government, historical experiences of cooperation, and early proxies of education and democracy ([Guiso, Sapienza, and Zingales, 2008, 2016](#); [Nunn and Wantchekon, 2011](#); [Tabellini, 2010](#))– as well as short-run factors –e.g., socioeconomic characteristics, recent traumatic experiences, discrimination, income shocks, the flow of information and communication, and war and violence ([Alesina](#)

¹⁰From [The Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database \(2019\)](#).

¹¹A similar analysis also reveals that the effect of female slavery, which is another group vulnerable to kidnapping, is similar and drives most of the negative effect on trust, rather than male slavery.

and La Ferrara, 2002; Ananyev and Guriev, 2019; Bellows and Miguel, 2008; Fisman and Khanna, 1999). This paper makes three contributions to this literature: i. we contribute to the research on the historical roots of trust by uncovering a specific mechanism –kidnapping incentives– that links the slave trade to persistent mistrust; ii. we identify conditions under which this effect is the strongest, highlighting the roles of price variation and proximity to trade networks within a simple cost-benefit analysis; iii. we repurpose child slave data as a novel proxy for kidnapping and cultural trauma of social betrayal.

Furthermore, the literature has explored the effects of slavery on various economic and political outcomes, including long-run development in Africa (Nunn, 2008; Whatley, 2022), industrialization in Britain (Eltis and Engerman, 2000), and productivity across U.S. states (Mitchener and McLean, 2003), as well as current political attitudes in the American South (Acharya, Blackwell, and Sen, 2016), post-colonial civil conflict (Besley and Reynal-Querol, 2014), and state-building across the globe (Sharman and Zarakol, 2024). We add to this literature by shedding new light on the persistence of mistrust. We attempt to unpack such persistence by identifying mechanisms, decompressing historical processes, and showing that the late slave trade of the 1800s exerted a substantial influence (coupled with oral testimonies). We anticipate that these findings will stimulate further discussion on the legacy of slavery in Africa.

More broadly, this paper adds to the work on the deep historical determinants of development by identifying a micro-level mechanism through which historical experience becomes embedded in social norms. Research shows that early institutional and economic conditions have lasting effects on contemporary outcomes.¹² We complement this work by showing how a historical market environment altered the incentives governing interpersonal behavior: where the returns to slave capture were higher, social predation became more profitable, mistrust became adaptive, and protective beliefs could subsequently be transmitted across

¹²See, for example, Borcan, Olsson, and Putterman (2018); Comin, Easterly, and Gong (2010); Galor and Özak (2016); Lowes (forthcoming); Michalopoulos, Putterman, and Weil (2019); Nunn (2008); Nunn and Wantchekon (2011); Putterman and Weil (2010). See also Cirone and Pepinsky (2022) for a review.

generations.

2 Historical Background and Conceptual Framework

2.1 Historical Background

The Atlantic slave trade was one of the largest forced migrations in history, involving the capture, transport, and sale of millions of enslaved Africans to the Americas. Although vast in scale, the intensity and effects of the trade within Africa varied sharply across space, reflecting geographic conditions (Esposito, 2022; Nunn and Puga, 2012) and proximity to slave markets (Whatley, 2022). The Atlantic slave trade was initiated by Portuguese explorers who originally set out for the west coast of Africa in search of gold (Lovejoy, 2011, p. 36), but soon began kidnapping and selling enslaved individuals to traders in Lagos in 1444-1445 (Klein, 2010, p. 53).

At the time, the trans-Saharan trade –originating around the 2nd century CE in the Sahel belt– was the dominant international slave trade in Africa (Fage, 1969; Falola and Heaton, 2008, p. 19; Klein, 2010, p. 7; Segal, 2002, p. 23).¹³ As Klein (2010) notes on the transition in intensity from the Saharan to the Atlantic slave trade (p. 9), “*the whole complex of enslavement practices from full-scale warfare and raiding of enemies to judicial enslavement and taxation of dependent peoples had come into use and would easily be adjusted to the needs of the Atlantic slave trade when this came into existence in the early fifteenth century.*” Hence, European traders integrated into existing networks of African kingdoms and merchants, reorienting inland markets toward the coast to meet growing external demand (Klein, 2010, p. 55; Wright, 2007, p. 45). The trans-Saharan slave trade is estimated to have displaced between five to nine million individuals over a millennium (Eltis et al., 2021, p. 538; Wright, 2007, p. 39), and it was not until the 17th century that the Atlantic trade

¹³African slaves were also exported through the Red Sea and Indian Ocean corridors, though to a lesser extent.

surpassed it in export intensity (Klein, 2010, p. 58; Wright, 2007, p. 45).¹⁴

One of the key reasons for the surge in the Atlantic slave trade was the spread of malaria across the Americas, which dramatically increased demand for enslaved Africans –especially from regions with high malaria suitability, as individuals from these areas were more likely to possess resistance to the disease (Esposito, 2022). This elevated demand, and the rise in prices that followed, strengthened incentives for local actors to capture and sell members of their own communities to slave traders. While the trans-Saharan trade averaged approximately 5,000 slave exports per year and continued alongside the Atlantic trade, Atlantic exports exceeded 100,000 annually at their peak.¹⁵

We next examine how this growing demand for captives shaped the methods through which people were enslaved, focusing particularly on opportunistic enslavement and social betrayal within communities.

2.2 Kidnapping, Social Betrayal, and the Transmission of Mistrust

In general, slave procurement methods included kidnapping, war captives, tributes, selling by relatives, judicial processes, and, in times of hardship, families selling their own members (Perbi, 2001; Hair, 1965; Nunn and Wantchekon, 2011). While the historical literature tends to emphasize wars and raids as a source of slavery, being taken through kidnapping, small-scale raids, and domestic judicial processes became increasingly common as the slave trade expanded (Perbi, 2001; Klein, 2010, p. 118-121; Wright, 2007, p. 41). For example, the Portuguese explorer Alvise Cadamosto writes: “*[The King of Senegal] supports himself by ordering the kidnapping of many slaves both from his own country and from those of his neighbors. He uses these slaves in many different ways, but above all to cultivate various landholdings made over to him. Moreover, he sells many of them to the Berber and Arab*

¹⁴Figure A.1 shows slave export intensities for the Atlantic and trans-Saharan slave trades from 600 CE to 1900 CE.

¹⁵Figure A.1 presents average estimated annual slave exports through the Sahara, based on three independent sources (Mauny, 1971, p. 240-241; Austen, 1979, p. 66; Wright, 2007, p. 39), and the Atlantic Ocean, from The Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database (2019).

merchants; and he has also begun to sell them to the Christians since they started transacting business in those lands". Cadamosto further reported that the people of Senegal mistrusted their leaders, as they *"would seize their wives and children to sell them as slaves for every slight failing"* (Wright, 2007, p. 44). Piot (1996) also notes that in matrilineal Kabre society in northern Togo, the maternal uncles sometimes sold off their sisters' children before the father could assert his claim. Another Portuguese explorer, André Álvares d'Almada, witnessed that households close to slave ports would also trick strangers on to slave-exporting ships (d'Almada, 1984), suggesting how reduced transaction costs, due to proximity to slave traders, facilitated opportunistic kidnapping.

In terms of primary quantitative data on the manner of enslavement, we are aware of only two sources. The first is "Koelle's informants", documented by Hair (1965), in which a sample of 179 freed slaves in Sierra Leone in 1850 were interviewed on the manner of their enslavement. Here, the most common manner of enslavement was being kidnapped or sold off by relatives and kinsmen (42%), followed by being taken in war (38%) or through debt and judicial processes (20%) (Hair, 1965). The second is the "Amistad interviews", where 37 former slaves were interviewed about their personal histories (Barber, 1840). These interviews reveal that 22 were kidnapped or tricked into slavery at or near their home village. Hence, in this sample, as many as 65% report being kidnapped into slavery, many of which were taken as children, and often by people of their own ethnicity. This echoes the view of Patterson (2018), who estimates that, while kidnapping was initially relatively rare, toward the late stages of the Atlantic slave trade, 70% were kidnapped and under 20% were victims of warfare.¹⁶ Often, victims of kidnapping were children, such as slave abolitionist Ottobah Cugoano, who was kidnapped together with a group of other children, and carried to the coast (Cugoano, 1787).

Because there is little direct quantitative data on manners of enslavement more broadly, we rely on demographic composition to approximate it empirically in Section 5. Following

¹⁶Our analysis of the child ratio among enslaved individuals over time in Figure A.2 is consistent with this view.

Boxell (2019), we use the prevalence of child slaves to capture those most vulnerable to being kidnapped by strangers, or sold or pawned by relatives or neighbors. Historical accounts corroborate this, emphasizing that children were particularly susceptible to being taken through means of kidnapping and debt pawning (Lovejoy, 2006; Sparks, 2014), and that children faced heightened risks of being kidnapped (Eltis and Engerman, 1993).¹⁷ This interpretation is also supported by oral testimony from West Africa: “*They could enter any house and kidnap the children whose parents had gone to the farm. They could also repeat the process between the hours of one o’clock and three o’clock in the afternoon when the parents had gone to the market. At night they could enter into the houses of widows and kidnap them and their children*” (Isichei, 1978). In contrast, adult males were more likely to be taken as captives in war (Geggus, 1989). Hence, variation in the likelihood of child slavery should be informative of the relative importance of kidnapping as a manner of enslavement.

Beyond the immediate incentive to kidnap, oral histories from West Africa provide unusually direct qualitative evidence on the transmission channel our framework relies on below: that fear born of the threat of kidnapping could be passed from parents to children and outlast the conditions that produced it. Isichei (1978) conducted several interviews with Nigerian Igbo elders from 1972 to 1975. One elder in his seventies reported in 1975 that:

My father had one [slave]. If you happen to capture someone, he becomes your slave. [...] In those days, you couldn’t walk three or four miles from Illah without fearing for your life, because there would be people lurking in the bushes. You could be in the farm working, and people would pounce on you and carry you away, to their town, and you would automatically become their slave. (Isichei, 1978)

Another elder, in his nineties, growing up before English colonization began, reports that:

¹⁷E.g., Sparks (2014) suggests that kidnapping of vulnerable individuals, commonly children, along the coast was common.

Just before the coming of the white man to Agulu, I was no longer a very small child. As a small child, I could remember that whenever my mother wanted to go to the farm to pick vegetables, she always hid us in the uno aja (clay house) and fastened the door. Could a child dare visit other children in the neighbourhood in those days? If a child tried it, he might succeed twice but not for the third time. He might be kidnapped even before the third attempt. (Isichei, 1978)

These testimonies speak directly to our conceptual framework below. First, they show how fear born of the threat of kidnapping propagated intergenerationally, from parent to child, within affected communities. Second, the fact that these childhood memories remained salient enough to survive major subsequent disruptions, including colonization, and to be retold within families decades later, is consistent with a mistrust heuristic that decays only slowly once established. As such, they offer rare direct evidence on the transmission channel we formalize below and test empirically in Section 5.

2.3 Conceptual Framework

Nunn and Wantchekon (2011) argue that the slave trade fostered mistrust by creating incentives for individuals to kidnap and sell relatives, friends, and neighbors, with cultural traits passed from parents to children sustaining this mistrust across generations. This is consistent with Guiso, Sapienza, and Zingales’s 2008 model of cultural transmission, in which societies at risk of low trust become trapped in a low-trust equilibrium, as parents instill conservative beliefs to protect their children against perceived threats. Since cultural change may be slow (Giavazzi, Petkov, and Schiantarelli, 2019) –consistent with the oral histories discussed in Section 2.2– this effect may persist even a hundred years after the slave trade ended. Nunn and Wantchekon (2011) abstract away from the mechanism of kidnapping and instead focus on reduced form effects of the slave trade on mistrust today. Here, we build a simple cost-benefit framework that yields testable predictions.

Consider an agent faced with the decision of whether to kidnap and sell a community

member to slave traders. The likelihood of engaging in such an act increases when the price of slaves is sufficiently high to outweigh the associated costs. Aggregating across such decisions within a community, let $K(\pi)$ denote the incidence of kidnapping, which increases with the profitability of kidnapping, π : $K'_\pi > 0$. The agent's profit function, $\pi(P, T)$, increases in the price of slaves, P , $\pi'_P > 0$, and decreases in transaction costs, T , $\pi'_T < 0$. These costs capture the logistical and physical challenges involved in kidnapping and delivering captives to slave traders.¹⁸

Greater exposure to kidnapping and social betrayal makes mistrust an adaptive response for members of the affected community. We allow this mistrust to persist through intergenerational transmission. Suppose that a fraction $\rho \in (0, 1)$ of the mistrust held by one generation is transmitted to the next, for example, through parental beliefs, warnings, and protective behavioral norms. An episode of kidnapping that occurred g_i generations before the present therefore contributes to contemporary mistrust with weight ρ^{g_i} . Letting $K_i(\pi_i)$ denote the incidence of kidnapping associated with slave trade event i , contemporary mistrust M_0 can be expressed as

$$M_0 = \theta \sum_{i=1}^n K_i(\pi_i) \rho^{g_i},$$

where $\theta > 0$ captures the effect of exposure to kidnapping and social predation on mistrust, and g_i is the number of intergenerational transmission steps separating event i from the present. Thus, mistrust today should be greater where kidnapping and social betrayal were historically more prevalent. Moreover, conditional on the intensity of such exposure, more recent episodes should exert a stronger influence on contemporary mistrust because the associated beliefs and behavioral norms have passed through fewer intergenerational transmission steps.

This simple framework therefore links the economic incentives generated by the slave trade to persistent mistrust through two stages. First, predetermined factors that affect

¹⁸We abstract from potential social or institutional costs that may also influence the agent's decision.

slave prices and transaction costs influence the profitability of kidnapping and, consequently, the extent to which members of a society turn against one another. Second, the mistrust generated by this environment of social predation may persist after the original incentives disappear through transmission of protective beliefs and behavioral norms across generations.

As noted earlier, the demand for slaves from malaria-suitable areas surged following the spread of malaria across the Americas, leading to significantly higher prices for slaves from those regions ([Esposito, 2022](#)). We therefore conjecture that malaria suitability, by increasing slave prices and the profitability of slavery, led to more kidnapping and social betrayal and, consequently, greater mistrust that could subsequently be transmitted across generations, conditional on a given level of slave trade. Furthermore, we expect this effect to be more pronounced in regions located closer to slave ports and Saharan trade hubs, where lower transportation costs further amplified the profitability of slave trading. Hence, heterogeneity in the effect of the slave trade on trust across these factors would provide evidence in favor of the mechanism proposed by [Nunn and Wantchekon \(2011\)](#).

Combined with the historical and qualitative evidence on kidnapping and its transmission discussed in Section 2.2, our framework thus provides us with four key hypotheses:

Hypothesis 1: The Trans-Atlantic slave trade led to greater mistrust in malaria-suitable areas, where slave prices were elevated due to their perceived suitability for malaria-endemic regions.

Hypothesis 2: The Trans-Atlantic slave trade led to greater mistrust among ethnicities closer to slave ports and slave trade hubs, where lower transaction costs increased profitability.

Hypothesis 3: Higher slave prices and lower transaction costs should be associated with more kidnapping, due to increased profitability.

Hypothesis 4: Greater exposure to kidnapping and social betrayal should correlate with a larger erosion of trust, with more recent episodes having a stronger influence, since fewer intergenerational transmission steps between the episode and present mean less cumulative

cultural decay.

3 Data

Outcomes

Trust— Following [Nunn and Wantchekon \(2011\)](#), we employ five trust questions from the individual level Afrobarometer Survey Round 3 of 2005.¹⁹ These measure: trust of relatives, trust of neighbors, trust of local council, intra-group trust, and inter-group trust (with four possible answers: not at all, just a little, somewhat, or a lot). Each trust question is recorded on this four-point ordinal scale, and we follow the broader trust literature in treating the responses as cardinal, and estimate all specifications by OLS ([Alesina and La Ferrara, 2002](#); [Guiso, Sapienza, and Zingales, 2008](#); [Nunn and Wantchekon, 2011](#)).

Child slave exports— To measure the degree of opportunistic enslavement, we draw on the demographic composition of slave cargoes recorded in [The Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database \(2019\)](#), the most spatially and temporally disaggregated source available on the Atlantic slave trade. The database compiles port-year-voyage-level shipping records for close to 36,000 documented voyages, drawn from ship manifests, prize-court records of captured vessels, customs registers, and merchant and captain correspondence. For a subset of voyages, these sources also report the age and sex composition of the enslaved individuals on board, recorded at either the African port of embarkation or the American port of disembarkation (precedence is given to disembarkation records where both survive); from this, [The Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database \(2019\)](#) constructs composite variables for the percentage of the cargo that was male (*Percentage male*) and the percentage classified as children rather than adults (*Percentage children*).²⁰ Demographic information of this kind survives for 4,213 voyages

¹⁹Round 3 is the only Afrobarometer wave with a complete, consistently worded set of trust questions: later waves retain only a subset of these measures with different question wording, and earlier waves include no trust questions.

²⁰Age and sex were recorded independently on different vessels: some report only a male/female split, others only an adult/child split, and relatively few report both for the same voyage, which prevents us from constructing a joint child-by-sex measure directly from the shipping records.

departing from 97 slave-exporting ports, representing 1.3 million embarked slaves, or a little more than 10% of the total volume of the Atlantic slave trade.

We use this information to construct two distinct measures. First, at the port-year-voyage level, we construct *Slave is a child*, a binary indicator equal to one if a given enslaved individual is recorded as a child (the dependent variable in Table 3). Second, at the ethnic-group level, we construct *Child slave exports*, a continuous measure comparable in scale and construction to the baseline *Slave trade* measure (an explanatory variable in Table 5), built in three steps. We first compute the implied number of child slaves per voyage as $Total\ embarked \times Percentage\ children$, and aggregate these counts to the port level, separately by century of departure. Second, because a child ratio is directly observed only for the subset of ports with demographic records, we interpolate a child ratio for every ethnic group in the [Murdock \(1959\)](#) Ethnographic Atlas via inverse-distance weighting (IDW): we compute the geographic distance between each ethnic group’s historical homeland centroid and every slave-exporting port, and weight each port’s contribution by the inverse of that distance, so that geographically closer ports receive more weight.²¹ Third, we multiply the interpolated child ratio by the ethnic group’s total slave-export intensity to obtain *Child slave exports*. We construct *Adult slave exports* as the residual, and analogous *Female slave exports* and *Male slave exports* measures using each voyage’s sex, rather than age, composition.

Variables of Interest

Slave trade— The baseline measure of slave trade intensity used by [Nunn and Wantchekon \(2011\)](#) is the number of slave exports normalized by area of land inhabited by the ethnic group, defined as $\log(1 + exports/area)$.

Malaria ecology— Following [Esposito \(2022\)](#), we use an exogenous Malaria ecology index from [Kiszewski et al. \(2004\)](#) —computed for the historical homeland of each ethnic group— to capture malaria prevalence and stability of transmission predicted on the basis of bio-

²¹Our baseline specification uses an IDW power parameter of one; results are robust to alternative power parameters (Tables B.1–B.2).

climatic characteristics. For ease of interpretation, we standardize the variable to have mean 0 and standard deviation 1. Figure A.3 shows the distribution of the Malaria ecology index for Africa.

Travel time to slave ports and Saharan trade hubs– To measure ethnicities’ proximity to slave ports and Saharan trade hubs, we use data on travel times from [Whatley \(2022\)](#).²² [Whatley \(2022\)](#) calculates the average travel time between each ethnic group’s historical homeland and the closest slave port and Saharan trade hub, using historical estimates of travel speed over a wide range of surfaces, climates, and modes of transportation. Hence, this variable implicitly captures local effects, e.g. rugged terrain ([Nunn and Puga, 2012](#)), rivers, and other geographic features, which may differentially affect ethnic groups’ exposure to the slave trade.²³

4 Effects of the Slave Trade by Slave Prices and Transaction Costs

We first examine whether factors that led to greater prices, such as malaria suitability, and facilitated supply by lowering transaction costs, such as proximity to slave markets or ports, drive the negative effects of the slave trade on trust.

4.1 Slave Prices and Mistrust

Our conceptual framework, presented in Section 2.3, motivates several sources of heterogeneity in the effect of the slave trade on mistrust. The first one is the elevated prices for African slaves with greater malaria resistance, which we proxy by local malaria suitability. Thus, to test *Hypothesis 1*, we estimate the following specification:

²²Figure A.3 shows the distribution of slave ports and Saharan trade hubs used in the analysis.

²³For control variables, we follow [Nunn and Wantchekon \(2011\)](#). See the discussion in there for more details.

$$\begin{aligned}
Trust_{i,e,d,c} = & \alpha_c + \beta Slave\ Trade_e + \delta Slave\ Trade_e \times Malaria\ Ecology_e \\
& + \gamma Malaria\ Ecology_e + \mathbf{X}'_{i,e,d,c} \mathbf{\Gamma} + \mathbf{X}'_{d,c} \mathbf{\Omega} + \mathbf{X}'_e \mathbf{\Phi} + \varepsilon_{i,e,d,c}
\end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

where i denotes individuals, e ethnic groups, d districts and c countries. $Trust_{i,e,d,c}$ denotes one of the five trust measures. We account for a number of controls at various disaggregation levels.²⁴ Standard errors, ε , are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity and district levels. Our parameter of interest is δ , which captures the differential effect of slave trade on trust by an ethnic group’s historical malaria exposure.

In Table 1, we report the results of our baseline specification. We find that the effect of the slave trade on mistrust for all five measures is driven specifically by areas of high malaria suitability. A key driver of the demand for African slaves was higher resistance to malaria, and, as malaria spread through the American continent in the 17th century, demand rose dramatically, leading to higher prices for slaves from malaria-suitable areas (Esposito, 2022). We argue that these elevated prices may have created stronger incentives for individuals to sell members of their own communities to slave traders, often through means of kidnapping or deception. Such practices arguably eroded social cohesion and contributed to persistent levels of interpersonal mistrust.

4.2 Transaction Costs and Mistrust

Table 2 tests *Hypothesis 2* and reports the estimates from interacting slave trade intensity with travel times to the nearest slave port and Saharan trade hub (akin to equation (1)).

We include both in the same regression, since, conditional on country fixed effects, the two

²⁴Following Nunn and Wantchekon (2011), we control for age, age squared, a gender indicator, five living conditions fixed effects, ten education fixed effects, 18 religion fixed effects, 25 occupation fixed effects, an indicator for whether the respondent lives in an urban location, a measure of ethnic fractionalization at the district level, the share of the district’s population that are the same ethnicity as the respondent, and 17 country fixed effects.

measures are negatively correlated and may thus attenuate each other if estimated separately.

We find a strong negative baseline effect of slave trade, which here is interpreted as the effect of slave trade intensity on the ethnicities closest to slave ports and Saharan trade hubs. The coefficients on the interaction of the slave trade and travel times are positive and statistically significant for all outcomes, suggesting that the negative effect of the slave trade on trust is driven by ethnicities closest to slave ports and Saharan trade hubs.

Figure 1 reveals that the negative effect of the slave trade on trust tapers off to zero at approximately 15-20 travel days from the closest slave port, and about 50-70 travel days from the closest Saharan trade hub. Since most of the transportation would occur by foot to slave ports and by trade caravans to Saharan trade hubs, it seems plausible that there is greater attenuation by travel time to slave ports.

These results align with our interpretation that proximity to slave markets reduced transaction costs, thereby increasing the profitability of slave trading and strengthening incentives for individuals to kidnap or trick members of their own communities into slavery.

5 Mechanisms

In this section, we assess the mechanism of kidnapping.

5.1 Slave Prices, Transaction Costs, and Child Slaves

As discussed in Section 2.2, we use the prevalence of child slaves in the [The Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database \(2019\)](#) shipping records as a proxy for opportunistic enslavement, following [Boxell \(2019\)](#).

Then, we test *Hypothesis 3* in Table 3 and report the results from child slavery regressions. We construct a binary indicator, *Slave is a child*, coded as 1 if the enslaved individual is recorded as a child in the slave export data (by port and decade), and 0 otherwise.

We start by examining the effect of higher prices proxied by malaria ecology. *Malaria Ecology* at the port level is calculated as the average malaria ecology value within a 200 km buffer

zone around each port coordinate.²⁵ Our main specification includes a quadratic coordinate polynomial that captures unobservable geographic characteristics varying smoothly across Africa. In column (1), we find a positive effect of malaria suitability on the probability that a slave is a child.²⁶ However, this may simply reflect baseline differences in demographics, perhaps due to a higher mortality rate in malaria-suitable regions.

To address this concern, in column (2), we exploit the fact that demand for slaves from malaria-suitable areas rose only after 1690, as malaria spread to the American continent (Esposito, 2022). Following the identification strategy of Esposito (2022), we interact malaria ecology with a post-1690 indicator to capture any differential effect of the increase in slave prices on the likelihood of child slaves in more malaria resistant areas. We find a positive effect of malaria suitability only for exports after 1690, and this effect is considerably larger than the baseline malaria effect. A one standard deviation increase in malaria suitability increases the probability that a slave is a child by 5.8 pp, relative to a sample mean of 19%. This corresponds to a 30% increase relative to the mean. These findings from columns (1) and (2) suggest that increased slave prices raised the likelihood of kidnapping of children into slavery.

As independent corroborating evidence, Figure 2 plots the Barbados slave price index alongside the share of children among slaves sold at auctions, using price and demographic data digitized from Galenson (1982)’s study of the Barbados slave market. Consistent with Esposito (2022), slave prices rise sharply after 1690, as malaria became endemic in the Americas. The share of slave children tracks this rise closely, increasing in tandem with prices through the early 1700s, as the Trans-Atlantic slave trade accelerated.

²⁵Since we cannot directly link the port-level data to ethnic groups, we compute malaria ecology within a buffer zone around each port rather than at the ethnic-group level.

²⁶We cluster standard errors at the port-level. Since ports tend to have overlapping catchments, we also use Conley standard errors to take into account potential spatial dependence in the error term (Colella et al., 2019). The lower bound on the bandwidths, 250km, roughly represents the catchment area of the average port, whereas the upper bound, 2000km, represents a third of the extent of the African continent, as recommended when accounting for spatial correlation in persistence studies (Conley and Kelly, 2025). In all cases, Conley standard errors are smaller than the clustered ones.

In addition, in the rest of Table 3, we find significant heterogeneity by distance to Saharan trade hubs.²⁷ Proximity to Saharan trade hubs exerts a significant and positive effect on the probability that a slave is a child. This suggests that lower transaction costs increased the likelihood of kidnapping of children into slavery.

Since this may simply be due to correlation with malaria suitability, we include both variables simultaneously in column (4). The conclusions do not change, implying that both malaria suitability and proximity to Saharan trade hubs played important roles for child slavery.

In column (5), we replace the coordinate polynomial with fixed effects for nine broad slave-exporting regions along the West, Central, and East African coasts.²⁸ This has no impact on the effect of malaria suitability, but diminishes the effect of proximity to Saharan trade hubs. This likely reflects the fact that there is substantially less within-region variation in proximity to Saharan trade routes.

5.2 Kidnapping, Child Slaves and Mistrust

Lastly, we test *Hypothesis 4* to understand whether there is a link between kidnapping proxied by child slavery and mistrust.

Since trust and slave trade are measured at the ethnicity level, we interpolate child slave exports for each ethnicity through inverse-distance weighting.²⁹ We compute slave trade intensity for children and adults separately with the expectation that child slavery will better capture the kidnapping channel.

Table 4 presents a simple mediation analysis of how much of the baseline effect of the

²⁷Because the outcome is measured at the port level, we cannot directly examine the effect of distance to slave ports. We use Euclidean distance between ports and Saharan trade hubs as our main measure of transaction costs, since the travel time estimates in [Whatley \(2022\)](#) are only available at the ethnic group level. However, the two measures are highly correlated at the ethnic group level ($\rho = 0.97$) and would likely yield similar results.

²⁸These regions are: Biafra, Bight of Benin, Gold Coast, Guinea, Senegambia, Sierra Leone, Southeast Africa, West Central Africa, and Windward Coast.

²⁹See Section 3 for details on the construction of *Child slave exports* via inverse-distance weighting, and Tables B.1–B.2 for robustness to the IDW power parameter.

slave trade on trust operates through child slave exports specifically. The “Baseline” in odd columns for each outcome reports the association between the aggregate *Slave trade* measure and trust, conditional on non-missing child slave export data. The estimates obtained are largely identical to those in [Nunn and Wantchekon \(2011\)](#). The even columns for each pair of trust outcome regressions add *Child slave exports* to the same specification. Once child slave exports are included, the baseline slave trade coefficients become small, positive, and statistically insignificant across all five trust measures, while the coefficients on child slave exports are negative and significant for four of the five outcomes. This indicates that the well-established negative effect of the slave trade on trust operates essentially through the extent of child slave exports, providing further support for kidnapping and other forms of opportunistic enslavement as the specific mechanism linking the slave trade to mistrust.

As an alternative way of assessing this relationship, Table 5 runs a horse race between child and adult slave exports for the full period, and split by time period. Regressions for the full period in Panel A confirm that the negative effect of slavery on trust is driven by child slaves, with no overall effect from adult slaves, in line with the idea that kidnapping led to greater mistrust.³⁰ However, we expect more recent traumatic events later in the slave trade to exert a greater influence on mistrust today and, thus, split the sample into two periods (pre-1800s, Panel B, and 1800s, Panel C), and estimate the regressions separately for each. We find that the negative effect of child slavery is driven primarily by the 1800s.³¹ In addition to taking place more recently, the prevalence of child slavery increased dramatically in the 1800s, as Figure A.2 shows, which suggests that kidnapping may not have been a prominent manner of enslavement until this period. Indeed, the mean share of child slaves in the Trans-Atlantic slave trade increased from 14% in the 1600s to 30% in the 1800s ([The](#)

³⁰These results are robust to various power parameters for the inverse-distance weights, Table B.2.

³¹If, instead, we treat female slaves as another group particularly vulnerable to kidnapping and compare female and male slave exports, we obtain similar results (see Table B.4). The corresponding mediation analysis, presented in Table B.3, likewise shows that the negative effect of the slave trade on trust operates primarily through female slave exports. Ideally, we would combine age and gender information to distinguish between child and adult male slave exports. However, relatively few voyages in the dataset report both age and gender for the same voyage, which prevents this analysis.

Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database, 2019).

The concentration of the effect in the nineteenth century also helps address a common concern in the persistence literature –a rich literature that finds effects lasting over several centuries, including Nunn and Wantchekon (2011)³² which has come under criticism recently (Abad, Maurer et al., 2021; Malik, Bouaroudj et al., 2021). One major concern is the “compression of history” (Austin, 2008), whereby potentially important events that occurred between the treatment and outcome tend to receive little consideration. Since child slave exports last peaked in the mid-nineteenth century,³³ and the Afrobarometer data were collected in 2005, the within-ethnic-group transmission of beliefs need only span roughly 100 years, or three to four generations, for the older respondents in our sample.³⁴ This is a relatively short horizon compared to much of the persistence literature. It is also consistent with the oral histories discussed in Section 2.2, which provide direct evidence that memories of kidnapping and the associated behavioral norms remained salient into at least the mid-1970s –within living memory of the parents and grandparents of our 2005 respondents.

6 Conclusion

This paper adds to understanding the long-run impact of the transatlantic slave trade on contemporary mistrust in Africa by uncovering a specific mechanism: the incentivization of kidnapping and social betrayal. We show that where slave prices were higher and transaction costs lower, individuals had stronger incentives to kidnap and sell others into slavery – ultimately fostering a culture of mistrust in those regions. Using child slave exports as a proxy for kidnapping, we document that this mechanism left a lasting imprint on trust, particularly in regions affected during the later stages of the trade. Oral testimonies further support

³²Some examples where effects last for several centuries are Alesina, Giuliano, and Nunn (2013), Valencia Caicedo (2019), and Guiso, Sapienza, and Zingales (2008).

³³As late as 1864, Samuel Crowther, the first African Anglican bishop of West Africa, reports about the dangers of being kidnapped into slavery when passing through the lands of the Igbo in modern-day Nigeria (Isichei, 1978).

³⁴Splitting the sample by age results in roughly equal effect sizes.

the intergenerational transmission of mistrust, revealing how behavioral norms shaped by the threat of enslavement endured long after the trade ended. These findings highlight the importance of micro-level mechanisms in understanding historical persistence and offer broader insights into how exploitative institutions shape social capital across generations.

References

- Abad, L.A., N. Maurer, et al. 2021. "History never really says goodbye: A critical review of the persistence literature." *Journal of Historical Political Economy* 1:31–68.
- Acharya, A., M. Blackwell, and M. Sen. 2016. "The political legacy of American slavery." *The Journal of Politics* 78:621–641.
- Alesina, A., P. Giuliano, and N. Nunn. 2013. "On the origins of gender roles: Women and the plough." *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 128:469–530.
- Alesina, A., and E. La Ferrara. 2002. "Who trusts others?" *Journal of Public Economics* 85:207–234.
- Algan, Y., and P. Cahuc. 2010. "Inherited trust and growth." *American Economic Review* 100:2060–2092.
- Ananyev, M., and S. Guriev. 2019. "Effect of income on trust: evidence from the 2009 economic crisis in Russia." *The Economic Journal* 129:1082–1118.
- Austen, R.A. 1979. "The Trans-Saharan Slave Trade: A Tentative Census." In H. A. Gemery and J. S. Hogendorn, eds. *The Uncommon Market: Essays in the Economic History of the Atlantic Slave Trade*. New York: Academic Press.
- Austin, G. 2008. "The 'reversal of fortune' thesis and the compression of history: Perspectives from African and comparative economic history." *Journal of International Development* 20:996–1027.
- Barber, J.W. 1840. *A History of the Amistad Captives: Being a Circumstantial Account of the Capture of the Spanish Schooner Amistad, by the Africans on Board; Their Voyage, and Capture near Long Island, New York; with Biographical Sketches of Each of the Surviving Africans; Also, an Account of the Trials Had on Their Case, Before the District and Circuit Courts of the United States, for the District of Connecticut*. EL & JW Barber.

- Bellows, J., and E. Miguel. 2008. "War and collective action in Sierra Leone." *Journal of Public Economics* 93:11–12.
- Besley, T., and M. Reynal-Querol. 2014. "The legacy of historical conflict: Evidence from Africa." *American Political Science Review* 108:319–336.
- Borcan, O., O. Olsson, and L. Putterman. 2018. "State history and economic development: evidence from six millennia." *Journal of Economic Growth* 23:1–40.
- Boxell, L. 2019. "Droughts, conflict, and the African slave trade." *Journal of Comparative Economics* 47:774–791.
- Cirone, A., and T.B. Pepinsky. 2022. "Historical persistence." *Annual Review of Political Science* 25:241–259.
- Colella, F., R. Lalive, S.O. Sakalli, and M. Thoenig. 2019. "Inference with arbitrary clustering.", pp. .
- Comin, D., W. Easterly, and E. Gong. 2010. "Was the wealth of nations determined in 1000 BC?" *American Economic Journal: Macroeconomics* 2:65–97.
- Conley, T.G., and M. Kelly. 2025. "The standard errors of persistence." *Journal of International Economics* 153:104027.
- Cugoano, O. 1787. *Thoughts and Sentiments on the Evil and Wicked Traffic of the Slavery and Commerce of the Human Species*.
- d'Almada, A.A. 1984. *Tratado Breve Dos Rios de Guiné Do Cabo-Verde*. Liverpool: University of Liverpool.
- Eltis, D., and S.L. Engerman. 1993. "Fluctuations in Sex and Age Ratios in the Transatlantic Slave Trade, 1663-1864." *Economic History Review*, pp. 308–323.

- . 2000. “The importance of slavery and the slave trade to industrializing Britain.” *The Journal of Economic History* 60:123–144.
- Eltis, D., S.L. Engerman, K.R. Bradley, C. Perry, P. Cartledge, D. Richardson, and S. Drescher. 2021. *The Cambridge World History of Slavery: Volume 2, AD 500-AD 1420*, vol. 2. Cambridge University Press.
- Esposito, E. 2022. “The side effects of immunity: Malaria and African slavery in the United States.” *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics* 14:290–328.
- Fage, J.D. 1969. “Slavery and the slave trade in the context of West African history.” *The Journal of African History* 10:393–404.
- Falola, T., and M.M. Heaton. 2008. *A history of Nigeria*. Cambridge University Press.
- Fisman, R., and T. Khanna. 1999. “Is trust a historical residue? Information flows and trust levels.” *Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization* 38:79–92.
- Galenson, D.W. 1982. “The Atlantic slave trade and the Barbados market, 1673–1723.” *The Journal of Economic History* 42:491–511.
- Galor, O., and Ö. Özak. 2016. “The agricultural origins of time preference.” *American Economic Review* 106:3064–3103.
- Geggus, D. 1989. “Sex ratio, age and ethnicity in the Atlantic slave trade: data from French shipping and plantation records.” *The Journal of African History* 30:23–44.
- Giavazzi, F., I. Petkov, and F. Schiantarelli. 2019. “Culture: Persistence and evolution.” *Journal of Economic Growth* 24:117–154.
- Greif, A. 1993. “Contract enforceability and economic institutions in early trade: The Maghribi traders’ coalition.” *The American Economic Review*, pp. 525–548.

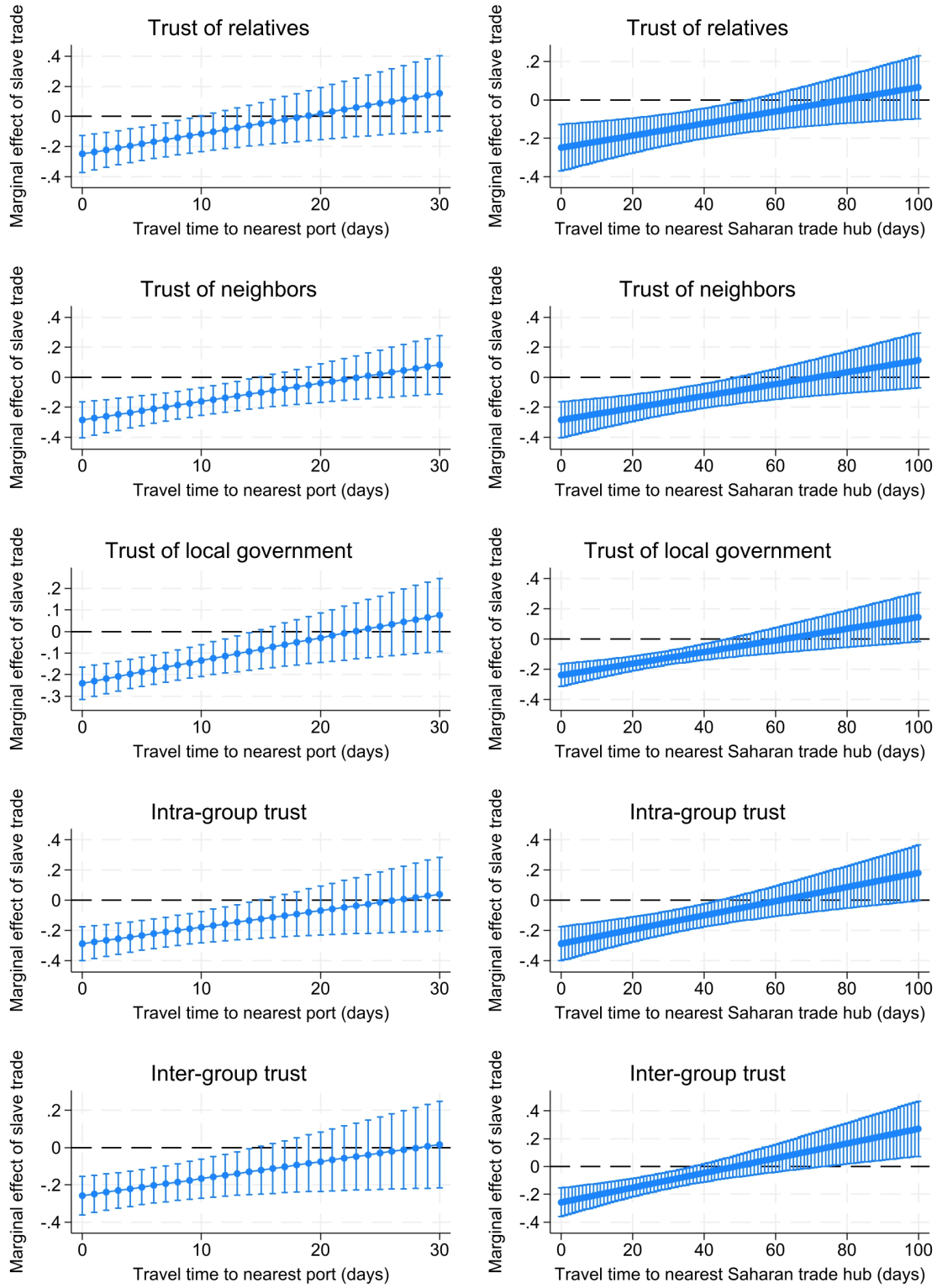
- Guiso, L., P. Sapienza, and L. Zingales. 2006. "Does culture affect economic outcomes?" *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 20(2):23–48.
- . 2016. "Long-term persistence." *Journal of the European Economic Association* 14:1401–1436.
- . 2008. "Social capital as good culture." *Journal of the European Economic Association* 6:295–320.
- Hair, P.E. 1965. "The enslavement of Koelle's informants." *The Journal of African History* 6:193–203.
- Herbst, J. 2000. *States and power in Africa: Comparative lessons in authority and control*. Princeton University Press.
- Isichei, E.A. 1978. "Igbo worlds: An anthology of oral histories and historical descriptions." (*No Title*), pp. .
- Kim, J., L. Putterman, and X. Zhang. 2022. "Trust, beliefs and cooperation: Excavating a foundation of strong economies." *European Economic Review* 147:104–166.
- Kiszewski, A., A. Mellinger, A. Spielman, P. Malaney, S.E. Sachs, J. Sachs, et al. 2004. "A global index representing the stability of malaria transmission." *American Journal of Tropical Medicine and Hygiene* 70:486–498.
- Klein, H.S. 2010. *The Atlantic slave trade*. Cambridge University Press.
- Knack, S., and P. Keefer. 1997. "Does social capital have an economic payoff? A cross-country investigation." *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 112:1251–1288.
- Levi, M., and L. Stoker. 2000. "Political trust and trustworthiness." *Annual Review of Political Science* 3:475–507.

- Lovejoy, P. 2006. "The children of slavery—the transatlantic phase." *Slavery and abolition* 27:197–217.
- Lovejoy, P.E. 2011. *Transformations in slavery: a history of slavery in Africa*, vol. 117. Cambridge University Press.
- Lowes, S. forthcoming. "Kinship structure and the family: Evidence from the matrilineal belt." *Journal of the European Economic Association*, pp. .
- Malik, A., V. Bouaroudj, et al. 2021. "The predicament of establishing persistence: Slavery and human capital in Africa." *Journal of Historical Political Economy* 1:411–446.
- Mauny, R. 1971. *Les siècles obscurs de l’Afrique noire: histoire et archéologie*. Fayard.
- Michalopoulos, S., L. Putterman, and D.N. Weil. 2019. "The influence of ancestral lifeways on individual economic outcomes in Sub-Saharan Africa." *Journal of the European Economic Association* 17:1186–1231.
- Mitchener, K.J., and I.W. McLean. 2003. "The productivity of US states since 1880." *Journal of Economic Growth* 8:73–114.
- Murdock, G.P. 1959. *Africa its peoples and their culture history*. McGraw-Hill Book Company, Inc.
- Nunn, N. 2008. "The Long-Term Effects of Africa’s Slave Trades." *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 123:139–176.
- Nunn, N., and D. Puga. 2012. "Ruggedness: The blessing of bad geography in Africa." *Review of Economics and Statistics* 94:20–36.
- Nunn, N., and L. Wantchekon. 2011. "The Slave Trade and the Origins of Mistrust in Africa." *American Economic Review* 101:3221–52.

- Ostrom, E. 1990. *Governing the commons: The evolution of institutions for collective action*. Cambridge University Press.
- Patterson, O. 2018. *Slavery and social death: A comparative study, with a new preface*. Harvard University Press.
- Perbi, A. 2001. "Slavery and the slave trade in pre-colonial Africa." *Retrieved August 20:2014*.
- Piot, C. 1996. "Of slaves and the gift: Kabre sale of kin during the era of the slave trade." *The Journal of African History* 37:31–49.
- Putnam, R.D., R.Y. Nanetti, and R. Leonardi. 1993. *Making democracy work: Civic traditions in modern Italy*. Princeton University Press.
- Putterman, L., and D.N. Weil. 2010. "Post-1500 population flows and the long-run determinants of economic growth and inequality." *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 125:1627–1682.
- Rothstein, B. 2005. *Social traps and the problem of trust*. Cambridge University Press.
- Sangnier, M., and Y. Zylberberg. 2017. "Protests and trust in the state: Evidence from African countries." *Journal of Public Economics* 152:55–67.
- Segal, R. 2002. *Islam's black slaves: The other black diaspora*. Macmillan.
- Sharman, J.C., and A. Zarakol. 2024. "Global slavery in the making of states and international orders." *American Political Science Review* 118:802–814.
- Sparks, R.J. 2014. *Where the Negroes are Masters*. Harvard University Press.
- Tabellini, G. 2010. "Culture and institutions: economic development in the regions of Europe." *Journal of the European Economic Association* 8:677–716.
- The Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database. 2019. "SlaveVoyages." <https://www.slavevoyages.org> (accessed May 4, 2023).

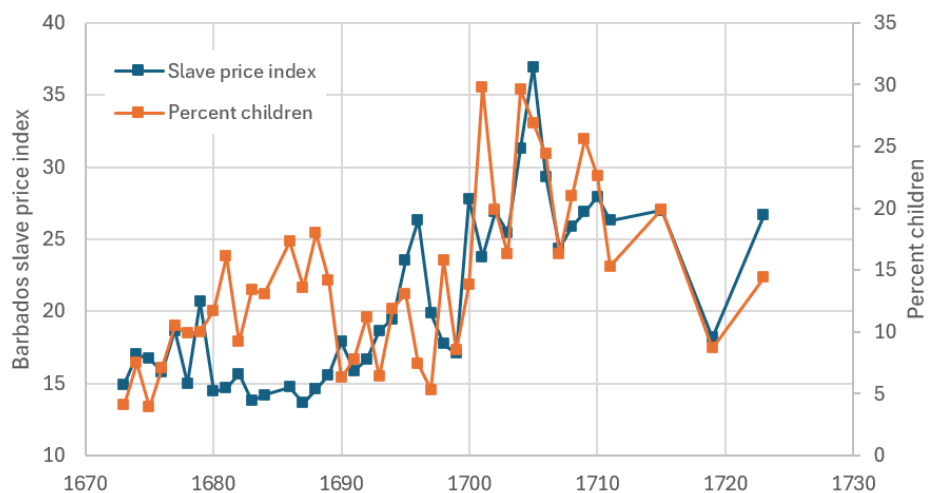
- Tilly, C., et al. 1992. *Coercion, capital, and European states, AD 990-1992*, vol. 29. Blackwell Oxford.
- Valencia Caicedo, F. 2019. “The mission: Human capital transmission, economic persistence, and culture in South America.” *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 134:507–556.
- Whatley, W. 2022. “How the International Slave Trades Underdeveloped Africa.” *The Journal of Economic History* 82:403–441.
- Wright, J. 2007. *The trans-Saharan slave trade*, vol. 2. Routledge.

Figure 1: Marginal effect of slave exports on trust by distance to slave markets



Notes: Estimates are based on marginal effects from the regressions in Table 2, conditional on *Travel time to nearest Saharan trade hub* (left) or *Travel time to nearest port* (right) set to zero for interpretability.

Figure 2: Barbados slave auction prices and the share of children sold, 1673–1723



Notes: Slave price index (left axis) and Percent children (right axis) among slaves sold at auctions in Barbados, 1673–1723. Data digitized from slave auction records reported in [Galenson \(1982\)](#).

Table 1: Slave Trade, Slave Prices proxied by Malaria Ecology, and Mistrust in Africa

Dependent Variable	Trust of relatives	Trust of neighbors	Trust of local council	Intra-group trust	Inter-group trust
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Slave trade	0.044 (0.039)	0.028 (0.053)	-0.004 (0.056)	0.038 (0.055)	0.100** (0.048)
Slave trade $\times$ Malaria ecology	-0.149*** (0.038)	-0.158*** (0.040)	-0.087** (0.042)	-0.153*** (0.039)	-0.164*** (0.035)
Malaria ecology	0.044 (0.032)	0.044 (0.035)	0.005 (0.047)	0.046 (0.040)	0.041 (0.036)
Controls	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
Observations	20,062	20,027	19,733	19,952	19,765

Notes: *Slave trade* is defined as $\log(1 + \text{slaveexports}/\text{area})$. *Malaria ecology*, computed for the historical homeland of each ethnic group, is from [Kiszewski et al. \(2004\)](#). *Intra-group trust* is trust for people from own ethnic group. *Inter-group trust* is trust for people from other ethnic groups. Controls include age, age squared, a gender indicator, five living conditions fixed effects, ten education fixed effects, 18 religion fixed effects, 25 occupation fixed effects, an indicator for whether the respondent lives in an urban location, a measure of ethnic fractionalization at the district level, the share of the district's population that are the same ethnicity as the respondent, and 17 country fixed effects. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity and district levels. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table 2: Slave Trade, Distance to Markets, and Mistrust in Africa

Dependent Variable	Trust of relatives (1)	Trust of neighbors (2)	Trust of local council (3)	Intra- group trust (4)	Inter- group trust (5)
Slave trade	-0.249*** (0.062)	-0.285*** (0.062)	-0.240*** (0.038)	-0.287*** (0.058)	-0.257*** (0.053)
Slave trade $\times$ Travel days to slave port	0.013*** (0.005)	0.012*** (0.004)	0.011*** (0.003)	0.011** (0.005)	0.009** (0.004)
Slave trade $\times$ Travel days to Saharan hub	0.003** (0.001)	0.004*** (0.001)	0.004*** (0.001)	0.005*** (0.001)	0.005*** (0.001)
Travel days to slave port	0.006** (0.003)	0.010*** (0.003)	0.004 (0.003)	0.010** (0.004)	0.006* (0.003)
Travel days to Saharan hub	-0.003* (0.002)	-0.003 (0.002)	-0.004* (0.003)	-0.004 (0.002)	-0.004 (0.002)
Controls	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
Observations	18,585	18,551	18,341	18,481	18,315

Notes: *Slave trade* is defined as $\log(1 + \text{slaveexports}/\text{area})$. *Travel days to slave port* and *Travel days to Saharan hub*, computed for the historical homeland of each ethnic group, are from [Whatley \(2022\)](#). *Intra-group trust* is trust for people from own ethnic group. *Inter-group trust* is trust for people from other ethnic groups. Baseline controls include age, age squared, a gender indicator, five living conditions fixed effects, ten education fixed effects, 18 religion fixed effects, 25 occupation fixed effects, an indicator for whether the respondent lives in an urban location, a measure of ethnic fractionalization at the district level, the share of the district's population that are the same ethnicity as the respondent, and 17 country fixed effects. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity and district levels. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table 3: Slaves Prices proxied by Malaria Ecology, Distance to Markets, and Kidnapping proxied by Child Slavery

Dep. Var.	Slave is a child				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Malaria ecology	0.022	-0.028		-0.017	-0.002
<i>Port cluster</i>	(0.018)	(0.020)		(0.021)	(0.021)
<i>Conley SE 250 km</i>	[0.012]*	[0.017]*		[0.017]	[0.024]
<i>Conley SE 1000 km</i>	[0.009]**	[0.015]*		[0.015]	[0.015]
<i>Conley SE 2000 km</i>	[0.009]**	[0.017]*		[0.018]	[0.018]
Malaria ecology $\times$ post-1690		0.058		0.057	0.059
<i>Port cluster</i>		(0.025)**		(0.026)**	(0.025)**
<i>Conley SE 250 km</i>		[0.016]***		[0.017]***	[0.022]***
<i>Conley SE 1000 km</i>		[0.015]***		[0.015]***	[0.018]***
<i>Conley SE 2000 km</i>		[0.016]***		[0.015]***	[0.018]***
Distance to Saharan trade hub			-0.148	-0.180	-0.094
<i>Port cluster</i>			(0.073)**	(0.068)***	(0.067)
<i>Conley SE 250 km</i>			[0.053]***	[0.051]***	[0.067]
<i>Conley SE 1000 km</i>			[0.047]***	[0.057]***	[0.064]
<i>Conley SE 2000 km</i>			[0.045]***	[0.056]***	[0.053]*
Coordinate polynomial	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
Region fixed effects	No	No	No	No	Yes
Decade fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,087,815	1,087,815	1,087,815	1,087,815	1,087,815

Notes: *Slave is a child* is a binary indicator equal to 1 if the slave is a child, and 0 otherwise. The coordinate polynomial is a quadratic function of longitude and latitude of each port. Region fixed effects correspond to nine slave-exporting regions located along the African coast. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table 4: Slave Trade, Child Slave Exports, and Mistrust: A Mediation Analysis

	Trust of relatives		Trust of neighbors		Trust of local council		Intra-group trust		Inter-group trust	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
	Baseline	+ Child	Baseline	+ Child	Baseline	+ Child	Baseline	+ Child	Baseline	+ Child
Slave trade	-0.133*** (0.036)	0.146 (0.120)	-0.158*** (0.034)	0.151 (0.135)	-0.111*** (0.021)	0.037 (0.100)	-0.142*** (0.032)	0.091 (0.127)	-0.095*** (0.028)	0.141 (0.109)
Child slave exports		-0.547** (0.261)		-0.604** (0.295)		-0.289 (0.185)		-0.456* (0.266)		-0.463** (0.214)
Observations	19,848	19,848	19,813	19,813	19,537	19,537	19,738	19,738	19,553	19,553

Notes: Each pair of columns reports OLS estimates of the effect of the slave trade on trust, without (Baseline) and with (+ Child) *Child slave exports* included in the same specification. *Slave trade* is defined as $\log(1 + \text{slave exports}/\text{area})$. *Child slave exports* is defined as $\log(1 + \text{child slave exports}/\text{area})$. *Intra-group trust* is trust for people from own ethnic group. *Inter-group trust* is trust for people from other ethnic groups. Baseline controls include age, age squared, a gender indicator, five living conditions fixed effects, ten education fixed effects, 18 religion fixed effects, 25 occupation fixed effects, an indicator for whether the respondent lives in an urban location, a measure of ethnic fractionalization at the district level, the share of the district's population that are the same ethnicity as the respondent, and 17 country fixed effects. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity and district levels.

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table 5: Effects of child slavery and adult slavery on trust

Dep. Var.	Trust of relatives (1)	Trust of neighbors (2)	Trust of local council (3)	Intra-group trust (4)	Inter-group trust (5)
Panel A: All periods					
Child slave exports	-0.596** (0.298)	-0.645* (0.336)	-0.294 (0.210)	-0.487 (0.305)	-0.509** (0.245)
Adult slave exports	0.184 (0.149)	0.185 (0.168)	0.043 (0.121)	0.115 (0.157)	0.177 (0.134)
Observations	19,848	19,813	19,537	19,738	19,553
Panel B: Pre-1800s					
Child slave exports	-0.409 (0.322)	-0.324 (0.345)	-0.056 (0.182)	-0.065 (0.307)	-0.038 (0.212)
Adult slave exports	0.045 (0.151)	-0.026 (0.158)	-0.118 (0.096)	-0.142 (0.154)	-0.114 (0.114)
Observations	19,848	19,813	19,537	19,738	19,553
Panel C: 1800s					
Child slave exports	-1.317 (1.309)	-2.313* (1.342)	-1.738 (1.078)	-2.810** (1.271)	-1.891* (1.134)
Adult slave exports	0.538 (0.742)	1.045 (0.788)	0.863 (0.641)	1.344* (0.746)	0.910 (0.675)
Observations	19,848	19,813	19,537	19,738	19,553

Notes: *Child slave exports* is defined as $\log(1 + \text{child slave exports}/\text{area})$. *Adult slave exports* is defined as $\log(1 + \text{adult slave exports}/\text{area})$. *Intra-group trust* is trust for people from own ethnic group. *Inter-group trust* is trust for people from other ethnic groups. Baseline controls include age, age squared, a gender indicator, five living conditions fixed effects, ten education fixed effects, 18 religion fixed effects, 25 occupation fixed effects, an indicator for whether the respondent lives in an urban location, a measure of ethnic fractionalization at the district level, the share of the district's population that are the same ethnicity as the respondent, and 17 country fixed effects. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity and district levels. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Online appendix for
“Demand for Slaves, Markets, and Social Betrayal: How the
Slave Trade Shaped Mistrust in Africa”

Table of Contents

Appendix A	Additional Figures	38
Appendix B	Additional Tables	41

A Additional Figures

Figure A.1: Annual slave exports through the Sahara and the Atlantic, based on data from [Wright \(2007\)](#) and [The Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database \(2019\)](#)

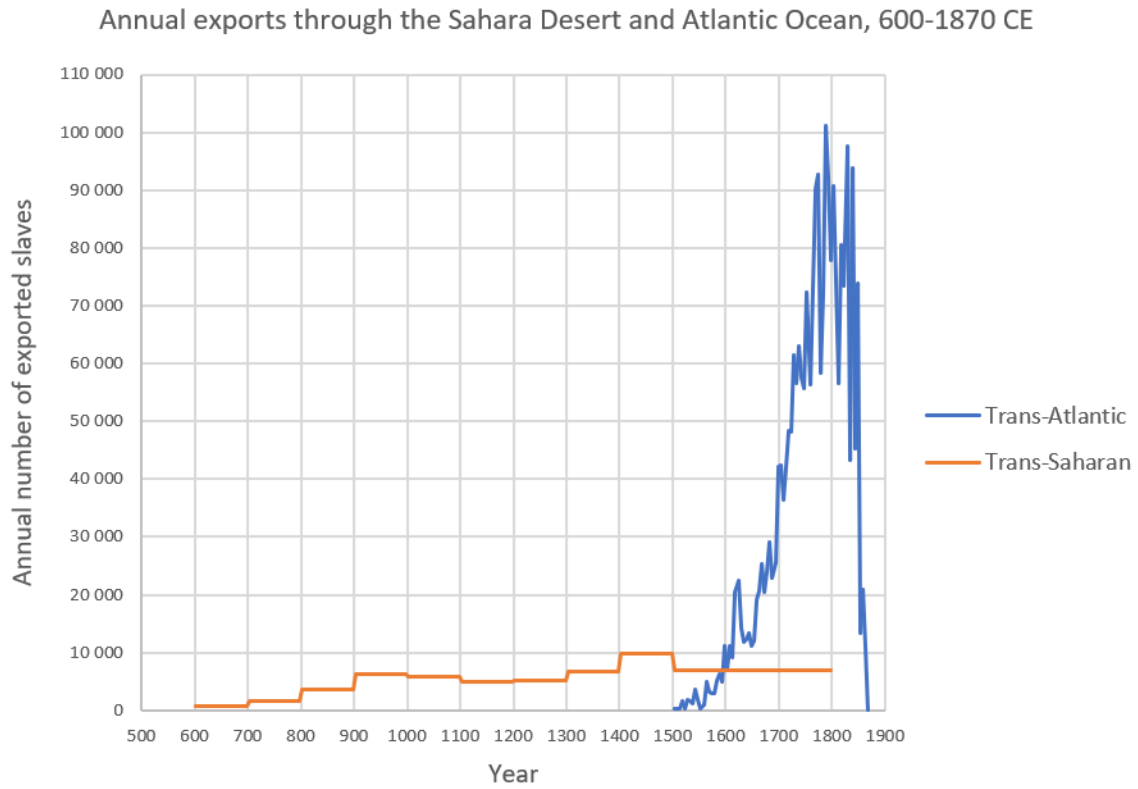


Figure A.2: Histogram of interpolated child slave ratios in our sample, for the pre-1800s and 1800s separately

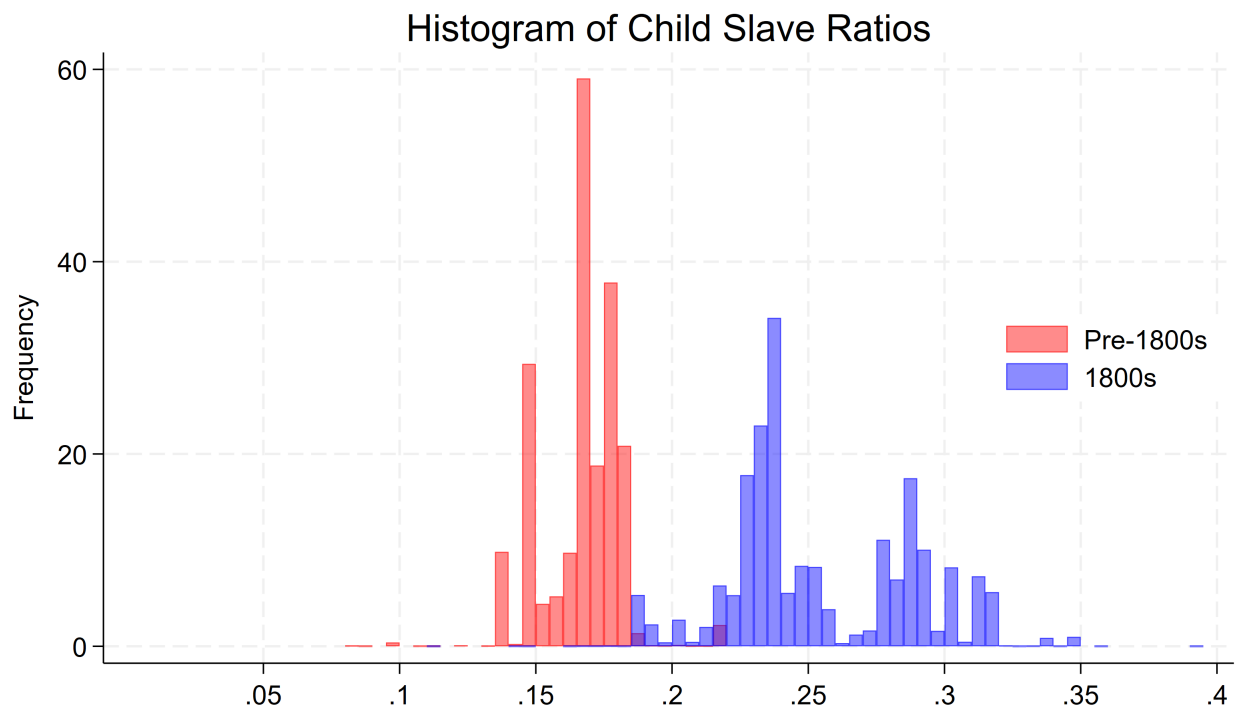
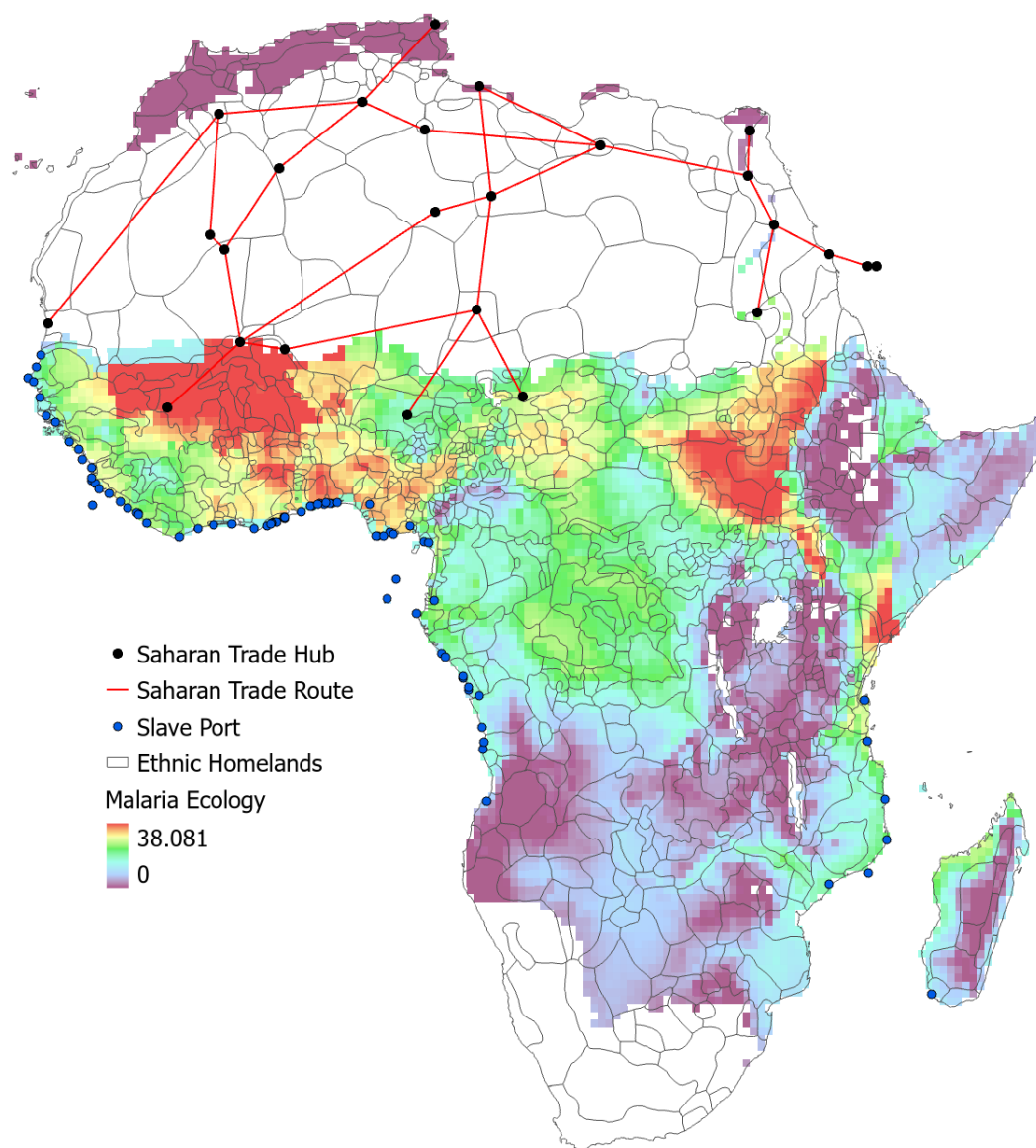


Figure A.3: Map of malaria suitability, historical slave ports, and Saharan trade hubs and routes



B Additional Tables

Table B.1: Spatial decay in slave exports by port distance and IDW power parameter p

Dep. Var.	Slave trade			
	$p = 0.5$	$p = 1$	$p = 1.5$	$p = 2$
$\sum_j \frac{1}{Dist_{ij}^p}$	0.123*** (0.022)	0.172*** (0.032)	0.186*** (0.068)	0.108 (0.079)
R^2	0.61	0.64	0.48	0.21
Observations	21,480	21,480	21,480	21,480

Notes: *Slave trade* is defined as $\log(1 + slaveexports/area)$ and measured at the ethnic group-level. $\sum_j \frac{1}{Dist_{ij}^p}$ is the sum of spatial weights in the IDW-interpolation of child and adult slave exports from port j to ethnicity i . Standard errors are clustered at the ethnicity level. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table B.2: Effect of child and adult slave trade on trust, by IDW power parameter p

Dep. Var.	Trust of relatives (1)	Trust of neighbors (2)	Trust of local council (3)	Intra-group trust (4)	Inter-group trust (5)
$p = 0.5$					
Child slave exports	-0.566* (0.288)	-0.603* (0.321)	-0.310 (0.205)	-0.419 (0.288)	-0.456* (0.233)
Adult slave exports	0.163 (0.142)	0.157 (0.159)	0.049 (0.117)	0.074 (0.149)	0.144 (0.128)
Observations	19,848	19,813	19,537	19,738	19,553
$p = 1$					
Child slave exports	-0.596** (0.298)	-0.645* (0.336)	-0.294 (0.210)	-0.487 (0.305)	-0.509** (0.245)
Adult slave exports	0.184 (0.149)	0.185 (0.168)	0.043 (0.121)	0.115 (0.157)	0.177 (0.134)
Observations	19,848	19,813	19,537	19,738	19,553
$p = 1.5$					
Child slave exports	-0.562* (0.311)	-0.619* (0.355)	-0.198 (0.205)	-0.492 (0.325)	-0.498** (0.251)
Adult slave exports	0.168 (0.158)	0.174 (0.180)	-0.010 (0.120)	0.120 (0.168)	0.174 (0.138)
Observations	19,848	19,813	19,537	19,738	19,553
$p = 2$					
Child slave exports	-0.380 (0.287)	-0.447 (0.337)	0.013 (0.188)	-0.353 (0.313)	-0.328 (0.235)
Adult slave exports	0.069 (0.150)	0.080 (0.174)	-0.130 (0.111)	0.044 (0.165)	0.081 (0.130)
Observations	19,848	19,813	19,537	19,738	19,553

Notes: *Child slave exports* is defined as $\log(1 + \text{child slave exports}/\text{area})$. *Adult slave exports* is defined as $\log(1 + \text{adult slave exports}/\text{area})$. *Intra-group trust* is trust for people from own ethnic group. *Inter-group trust* is trust for people from other ethnic groups. Baseline controls include age, age squared, a gender indicator, five living conditions fixed effects, ten education fixed effects, 18 religion fixed effects, 25 occupation fixed effects, an indicator for whether the respondent lives in an urban location, a measure of ethnic fractionalization at the district level, the share of the district's population that are the same ethnicity as the respondent, and 17 country fixed effects. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity and district levels. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table B.3: Slave Trade, Female Slave Exports, and Mistrust: A Mediation Analysis

	Trust of relatives		Trust of neighbors		Trust of local council		Intra-group trust		Inter-group trust	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
	Baseline	+ Female	Baseline	+ Female	Baseline	+ Female	Baseline	+ Female	Baseline	+ Female
Slave trade	-0.133*** (0.036)	0.207 (0.134)	-0.158*** (0.034)	0.214 (0.151)	-0.111*** (0.021)	0.091 (0.120)	-0.142*** (0.032)	0.132 (0.142)	-0.095*** (0.028)	0.188 (0.126)
Female slave exports		-0.547** (0.238)		-0.597** (0.265)		-0.324* (0.184)		-0.441* (0.239)		-0.454** (0.200)
Observations	19,848	19,848	19,813	19,813	19,537	19,537	19,738	19,738	19,553	19,553

Notes: Each pair of columns reports OLS estimates of the effect of the slave trade on trust, without (Baseline) and with (+ Female) *Female slave exports* included in the same specification. *Slave trade* is defined as $\log(1 + \text{slave exports}/\text{area})$. *Female slave exports* is defined as $\log(1 + \text{female slave exports}/\text{area})$. *Intra-group trust* is trust for people from own ethnic group. *Inter-group trust* is trust for people from other ethnic groups. Baseline controls include age, age squared, a gender indicator, five living conditions fixed effects, ten education fixed effects, 18 religion fixed effects, 25 occupation fixed effects, an indicator for whether the respondent lives in an urban location, a measure of ethnic fractionalization at the district level, the share of the district's population that are the same ethnicity as the respondent, and 17 country fixed effects. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity and district levels. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table B.4: Effects of female and male slave exports on trust

Dep. Var.	Trust of relatives (1)	Trust of neighbors (2)	Trust of local council (3)	Intra-group trust (4)	Inter-group trust (5)
Panel A: All periods					
Female slave exports	-1.062** (0.419)	-1.143** (0.480)	-0.599* (0.355)	-0.953** (0.453)	-0.951** (0.380)
Male slave exports	0.704** (0.322)	0.740** (0.369)	0.356 (0.294)	0.606* (0.352)	0.659** (0.304)
Observations	19,848	19,813	19,537	19,738	19,553
Panel B: Pre-1800s					
Female slave exports	-0.879* (0.526)	-0.946* (0.571)	-0.171 (0.365)	-0.667 (0.541)	-0.374 (0.387)
Male slave exports	0.540 (0.413)	0.566 (0.440)	-0.020 (0.302)	0.359 (0.424)	0.163 (0.311)
Observations	19,848	19,813	19,537	19,738	19,553
Panel C: 1800s					
Female slave exports	-1.587 (1.221)	-2.640** (1.072)	-2.284** (0.931)	-2.829*** (1.057)	-2.121* (1.081)
Male slave exports	0.758 (0.720)	1.340** (0.655)	1.278** (0.583)	1.467** (0.656)	1.129 (0.691)
Observations	19,848	19,813	19,537	19,738	19,553

Notes: *Female slave exports* is defined as $\log(1 + \text{female slave exports}/\text{area})$. *Male slave exports* is defined as $\log(1 + \text{male slave exports}/\text{area})$. *Intra-group trust* is trust for people from own ethnic group. *Inter-group trust* is trust for people from other ethnic groups. Baseline controls include age, age squared, a gender indicator, five living conditions fixed effects, ten education fixed effects, 18 religion fixed effects, 25 occupation fixed effects, an indicator for whether the respondent lives in an urban location, a measure of ethnic fractionalization at the district level, the share of the district's population that are the same ethnicity as the respondent, and 17 country fixed effects. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity and district levels. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$